

Hey, everybody. Welcome to your Chapter 3 review. In this episode, we'll discuss the relationship between our mind and fitness. And as always, we'll cover key learning points from the chapter.

Psychology examines the relationship between brain functionality and human behavior, or in our case, the impact on exercise and fitness. Every single person is a unique individual with their own history, motivations, anxieties, lifestyles, and support systems. At the same time, there are commonalities. And when you learn to recognize them, they become easier to address using proven, effective methods. Just like you have your own reasons for going into a profession as a CPT, people have their own reasons for seeking out the help of a fitness professional.

Psychology plays a vital role in fitness and wellness and influences our decisions to either be physically active or not active on any given day. Fundamentally, everyone knows that physical activity is good for them. But building healthy, consistent habits can be difficult. It's going to be part of your job to uncover what makes each person tick and how to keep them on track. Luckily, NASM has done some of the heavy lifting by defining an approach to understanding the psychology side of things, including how to identify specific motivations to participate and overcome barriers, as well as buttoning down a good social support system.

Just remember, the role of psychology can also extend to some clinical issues, like exercise addiction or poor body image associated with eating disorders. Issues like these are beyond the scope of practice for a CPT. Psychologists and psychiatrists are trained, licensed professionals who treat people with mental illnesses and conditions of this type and should be your go-to referral when you think a client needs help outside of what you can and should offer within your scope of practice.

Once you complete this chapter, you should be able to describe common reasons why people avoid regular exercise, evaluate various social influences on exercise adherence, recommend the best forms of support to help clients adhere to exercise, and identify the psychological benefits of regular exercise. Let's dig into this thought-provoking subject.

The role of psychology in fitness and wellness deals with several topics, including the way exercise participation affects someone's short-term and long-term mood; the effect of weight loss on self-esteem; the motivations to become physically active; and how social influences affect overall exercise behavior. One of the most important things about psychology and its relationship with fitness and wellness is the role it plays in the behavioral change process.

Since an alarming number of people don't participate in regular physical activity, there is an ongoing need for interventions that address behavioral change, specifically in helping people transition from a sedentary lifestyle to an active one. Bottom line is to make fitness a habit, people have to learn to value and prioritize exercise within the demands of everyday life, from family, work, and other competing interests, like leisure time.

When working with someone who's new to exercise or returning to exercise, behavioral change can be guided by finding out why these clients want to participate and what has perhaps stopped them in the past. One of the most important things to uncover is whether the client responds better to intrinsic or extrinsic motivations or a combination of both. Extrinsic motivation happens when someone does something for rewards or recognition, like having their name on top of the leaderboard in class or winning a trophy.

Intrinsic motivation describes the motivation to do something that comes from within, like feelings of self-satisfaction and overcoming obstacles. Clinically speaking, we find that intrinsic motives are the most strongly related to long-term adherence. But hey, a little healthy competition may give things a boost as well. Either way, uncovering this information will help you influence their goal setting and create a program based on the types of exercise necessary to meet their needs.

Another aspect of successful behavioral change is helping clients to identify their barriers to exercise and provide suggestions about how to overcome them. Some barriers are physical, like an illness or injury. But others are based in perception and commonly include lack of time, setting unrealistic goals, lack of a social support system, social physique anxiety, and inconvenience or ambivalence toward the idea of exercising. Regardless of the barrier, it's your job to help them find a way up, over, through, or around it.

Barriers will be a constant battle for some, and they can change as people age and responsibilities shift. However, many barriers can be wiped out or minimized with some basic strategies that provide realistic solutions or alternatives. For example, lack of time can be minimized by improved time management skills and reevaluating daily priorities.

Unrealistic goals can be dealt with by actively engaging with your clients about setting appropriate outcomes and process goals. Social physique anxiety, which can truly be crippling for some folks, can be avoided by finding activities that reduce the anxiety triggers and help create a safe and comfortable exercise environment. We've also heard the one about how inconvenient exercise can be. That perception can be overcome by making the exercise experience as appealing as possible, both by providing excellent customer service and clean facilities and by helping clients find ways to exercise outside of the fitness facility, if that's a better fit for them.

Social influences on exercise can come from other people, the internet, or the environment, and these influences can lead people both toward and away from exercise. However, you've heard me mention a couple of types of support, and that's really what it all comes down to. Lack of support can become an obstacle to exercise. But properly leveraging support can make exercise more appealing and feasible.

Let's look at the types of support to consider. Instrumental support includes tangibles like having transportation to a fitness facility, finances, or childcare. This is often a big deal for that inconvenience crowd we mentioned earlier. Emotional support, on the other hand, comes from being caring, empathetic, and concerned about someone's experience with exercise. The ability to be empathetic and relate to the way another person feels or views a situation can be a make or break skill, particularly in a service-based industry.

Companionship support is literally when someone exercises with another person. For many people, having a workout buddy can make things more fun. Informational support is one of the main reasons people seek out a fitness professional. It involves providing accurate and current information about exercise and wellness. It can be a great way to break through ambivalence by continuing to add to the list of benefits the client may be checking off in their mind.

And you can pretty much bet things will change over time. Clients will all have different needs and expectations, particularly with sources of social support. With the dynamics of support and obstacles always shifting, it's crucial to have a good line of communication with your clients and revisit goals and obstacles on a regular basis.

Now let's talk about how you influence your clients. As the exercise leader, you set the entire tone of the program and are responsible for creating an inviting and inclusive environment. Forming an exercise group can be one way to provide both accountability and additional encouragement. You can also take advantage of community influences.

Look at the safety level of the exercise environment and the opportunities for exercise in the areas around you. Play around with ideas to get your group out on sidewalks, green spaces, playgrounds, and walking trails. Keep it safe, but don't be afraid to find different environments and settings that appeal to the vibe of your group.

Overall, fitness professionals can best serve their clients by utilizing excellent communication skills. Both listening and explaining are critically important in making sure that an accurate exchange of information takes place. You can also offer scientific facts about how exercise provides several psychological benefits, which can enhance overall well-being. It goes well beyond a physical transformation and can include improved mood, better sleep quality, increased self-esteem, improved body image, and fewer depression and anxiety symptoms.

So I think it's pretty clear that psychology plays a vital role in fitness and wellness. As a CPT, you have a wealth of psychological principles to borrow from. Identifying specific motivations to participate, strategies to overcome barriers, and identifying social support systems will be invaluable to your clients. Exercising regularly really is a legitimate challenge for most people. Trainers need to empathize and realize that no two people are the same.

With your guidance and support, you can play an important role in helping your clients develop lifelong habits that promote physical and mental well-being. After all, excellent customer service reaches beyond the ability to create unique and progressive programs for the body and taps into the power of the mind to create real change from within. Happy studying.